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Participant Journaling as a Data Collection Method in Management Education Research

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Abstract

Purpose

This paper examines participant journaling as a qualitative data collection method in management education research. It aims to analyze how journaling can illuminate student learning experiences, capture developmental processes, and provide insights into pedagogical effectiveness while identifying best practices and methodological challenges.

Design/methodology/approach

The study employs an integrative literature review methodology, analyzing peer-reviewed articles from multiple databases including Academic Search Premier, ERIC, PsycINFO, and Business Source Premier. The review spans the past 20 years, focusing on journaling applications in management education and related fields.

Findings

The review reveals that participant journaling offers unique advantages for studying management education, including real-time documentation of learning processes, longitudinal tracking of skill development, and capture of reflection-in-action. Key challenges include maintaining student engagement, ensuring assessment consistency, and managing data complexity. The study identifies theoretical frameworks underpinning journaling methodology, including experiential learning theory, transformative learning theory, and critical management education.

Originality

This paper provides the first comprehensive review of participant journaling specifically within management education research contexts. It extends existing literature by synthesizing theoretical foundations, identifying unique methodological considerations for management education settings, and proposing research directions for advancing journaling as a rigorous qualitative method in management education scholarship.

Research limitations/implications

The review suggests the need to develop systematic approaches for journal analysis and standards for quality assessment in management education research contexts.

Keywords: participant journaling, management education, qualitative methods, student reflection, SoTL

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Introduction

Participant journaling is a qualitative research method that involves asking study participants to regularly record their experiences, thoughts, feelings, and reflections in a personal journal or diary (Hayman et al., 2012). Ward et al. (2020) describe participant journaling as the process of participants sharing their thoughts, ideas, feelings, and experiences through writing or other media. It is commonly used in qualitative research studies to record participant experiences in their natural contexts (Ward *et al.*, 2020). Participant journaling can provide valuable insights into various areas, such as individual well-being, physical activity, stress management, and reflective learning.

In management classrooms, journaling has been used to document leadership development, capture experiential learning outcomes, track cross-cultural competency development, and assess ethical decision-making processes. However, systematic examination of journaling as a research method, specifically within management education contexts, remains limited. Research has utilized participant journals in diverse fields e.g. nursing (Mackrill, 2007), education (Broom et al., 2014; Garvis, 2012), and social work (Khan, 2014). In the field of sport management, Doyle et al. (2016) used participant journaling to explore the individual-level benefits of sport consumption. They found that journaling provided qualitative data on the activation of positive emotions, engagement, relationships, meaning, and accomplishment in the context of sport spectatorship.

In the wake of COVID-19 pandemic, participant journaling was used to explore the experiences of college students during the challenging time (Strehli *et al.*, 2022). Macedonia & Weiss (2022) utilized participant journals and follow-up interviews to understand the experiences of special education teachers during a global pandemic. The combination of journals and

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interviews allowed for a deeper understanding of participant perspectives on support. Participant journaling has been utilized in teacher education to analyze the types of reflection in which pre-service teachers engage (Minott, 2008).

Broom et al. (2014) highlighted the potential use of participant diaries or journals as a data collection technique. They noted that while researcher journals have been commonly used, there has been limited attention given to participant journals. However, participant journals can provide valuable insights into self-care practices and everyday lay expertise. Participant journaling produces rich qualitative data that provides insider perspectives on complex phenomena. When integrated thoughtfully into research design, it can yield compelling insights into subjective realities.

There are several advantages to using participant journaling as a data collection method. It can provide a more in-depth and nuanced understanding of participants' experiences than other methods, such as interviews or focus groups. This is because journaling allows participants to reflect on their experiences at length and in their own words. Journaling can capture participants' thoughts and feelings in real-time, which can be helpful for understanding how they are experiencing a particular event or situation. Journals capture information in the participant's own words and from their point of view. This can reveal subjective perspectives that may not emerge clearly in other data collection approaches (Jacelon & Imperio, 2005). Journaling can be a relatively low-cost and low-resource data collection method, as it does not require the researcher to be present with the participants. Participant journals allow researchers to obtain longitudinal data on changes over time. Unlike one-time interviews or surveys, journals provide insights into how participants' perceptions and experiences evolve (Hayman et al., 2012). The journaling process encourages reflection and meta-cognition. Articulating thoughts in writing causes participants to

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be more conscious of their cognitive processes (Ullrich and Lutgendorf, 2002). Journals tend to facilitate expression of emotional content. Participants may feel more comfortable disclosing sensitive experiences and feelings in a private journal than face-to-face (Hayman et al., 2012).

However, there are also some potential limitations to using participant journaling. It can be difficult to get participants to commit to journaling regularly. Participants may not be comfortable writing about their experiences, especially if they are sensitive or personal. The researcher may need to spend time coding and analyzing the journal entries, which can be time-consuming. Unclear/disorganized entries requiring interpretation, recall bias, and reactivity where the act of journaling itself influences thoughts and behaviors (Hayman et al., 2012). Despite these limitations, participant journaling can be a valuable data collection method in a variety of research contexts.

Objectives and Justification of Study

While journaling holds promise, several conceptual gaps remain in leveraging its full potential and situating it within a qualitative research paradigm. This review attempts to synthesize current knowledge, critically assess the method, and point the way forward for researchers through proposed standards and an agenda for future research in management education. Thus, the main objective of this study is to provide a comprehensive conceptual review and critical appraisal of participant journaling as a qualitative research method. The Justification for this study is that participant journaling is an emerging qualitative method that warrants critical examination and conceptual development. However, existing literature on journaling is dispersed across disciplines and lacks synthesis. No consensus exists on best practices for journaling in research contexts and standards are lacking for journal data analysis and reporting. Further conceptual work is needed to evaluate merits and limitations of journaling.

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Research Questions

The paper addresses several key questions:

- What are the origins and conceptual foundations of participant journaling?
- What are the proposed strengths and benefits of using participant journals for qualitative data collection?
- How can participant journaling illuminate student learning experiences and developmental processes in management education?
- What are the unique benefits and challenges of using journaling methods in management education research?
- What best practices can be recommended for implementing participant journaling in management education studies?
- How can journaling data be effectively analyzed to generate insights for management education scholarship?
- What future research directions can be identified to further develop journaling as a research method?

Method of Inquiry

In our attempt to answer the research questions, an in-depth review of existing academic literature was conducted to synthesize current knowledge and evidence on participant journaling as a qualitative research method in management education. The literature search spanned several databases, including Academic Search Premier, CINAHL, ERIC, PsycINFO, Google Scholar, Web of Science and PubMed, focusing on core disciplines utilizing journaling methods such as education, nursing, psychology, and the social sciences. The search was limited to peer-reviewed articles available in English language published within the past 20 years, in order to concentrate

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on contemporary discourse and conceptualizations of journaling. Initial search terms included "participant journaling", "solicited diaries", "participant diaries", and associated terms, which yielded an initial corpus of 67 articles for review. Further snowball sampling was undertaken, mining reference lists of relevant articles to identify additional sources.

Key themes extracted through a process of inductive coding included the conceptual origins of journaling, proposed strengths and benefits, critiques and limitations, strategies for effective implementation, methodological concerns, and future directions. The literature reviewed spanned empirical studies utilizing journaling methods, methodological examinations of journal techniques, conceptual reviews, and theoretical discussions situating journaling within qualitative paradigms. This integrative review synthesizes the current state of knowledge and debates regarding journaling within research contexts in management education.

Emergence of Participant Journaling as a Qualitative Social Science Research Method

Participant journaling has emerged as a qualitative research method in the past 10-15 years. Though participant journals have long been used in clinical fields like education and counseling, their adoption as a social science research tool is relatively recent. Several factors account for the growing use of participant journaling in qualitative research. There has been a growing recognition of the value of qualitative research in capturing rich and detailed accounts of participants' experiences, perceptions, and emotions (Pearce et al., 2019). Qualitative research has gained traction in various disciplines, including the business, social sciences, clinical sciences, and interdisciplinary studies (Pearce et al., 2019). This recognition has led to increased interest in and adoption of qualitative and mixed methods approaches (Pearce et al., 2019). Advancements in research methodologies have contributed to the emergence of participant journaling as a viable data collection method.

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Researchers have been exploring and refining various methods for synthesizing qualitative research (Barnett-Page and Thomas, 2009). The critical incident technique, a qualitative research method that has been widely used for several decades, has influenced the development of participant journaling (Butterfield *et al.*, 2005). The adoption of mixed methods research, which has also contributed to the emergence of participant journaling. Mixed methods research has gained acceptance and use across disciplines (Plano Clark, 2010). Participant journaling can be integrated into mixed methods studies to provide qualitative insights that complement quantitative data (Nassaji, 2015).

There is the shift towards more participatory research models that recognize participants as collaborators rather than just subjects (Hall *et al.*, 2021) and journaling is seen as empowering participants. There is also the desire for richer, more detailed qualitative data than traditional post-hoc interviews can provide. Participant journals offer real-time insights (Hayman *et al.*, 2012a). Technological developments like mobile apps and web platforms that allow digital journaling has broaden accessibility (Jacelon & Imperio, 2005). Recognition of the value of subjective narratives and phenomenological experiences as research data has been critical to the acceptance of Participant Journaling (Dodgson, 2023; Ide and Beddoe, 2023). Critiques of problems like retrospective bias in interview data lead researchers to explore alternatives like journaling (Mansfield *et al.*, 2023). Innovations in analytic approaches like narrative analysis and thematic analysis better equip researchers to study participant journal data.

Conceptual and Theoretical Underpinnings

Participant journaling can be situated within traditions such as reflective practice and phenomenology, as it shares common elements and objectives with these approaches (Vicary *et al.*, 2017). Reflective practice involves the process of self-reflection and critical analysis of one's

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experiences, actions, and beliefs. It aims to enhance professional development, improve decision-making, and promote learning. Participant journaling aligns with reflective practice as it provides individuals with a structured platform to reflect on their experiences, thoughts, and emotions. By engaging in journaling, participants can deepen their understanding of their own experiences and gain insights into their own actions and beliefs. Phenomenology, on the other hand, focuses on understanding the lived experiences of individuals and the meanings they attribute to those experiences (van Manen, 2017). It aims to explore the essence of human experiences and the subjective perspectives of individuals. Participant journaling can be seen as a phenomenological method as it allows individuals to express their subjective experiences and provide rich descriptions of their thoughts, feelings, and perceptions.

Several theoretical traditions have informed the use of journaling in social science research, including phenomenology's focus on lived experiences, reflexive practice's emphasis on critical reflection, and feminist approaches giving voice to personal narratives (Oliphant and Bennett, 2020; Smith *et al.*, 2009). Participant journaling aligns with the interpretivist paradigm and constructionist epistemology underpinning much qualitative research (Vicary *et al.*, 2017). Table 1 describes how participant journaling emerges from and aligns with several conceptual traditions focused on subjectivity, meaning-making, critical reflection, and empowerment. Participant journaling in management education aligns with several key theoretical traditions.

Experiential Learning Theory (Kolb)

Kolb's experiential learning theory provides a robust foundation for participant journaling in management education by emphasizing the cyclical nature of learning through concrete experience, reflective observation, abstract conceptualization, and active experimentation (Kolb and Kolb, 2009). Journals serve as a structured tool for students to document and process their

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management learning experiences through this cycle. When students record their concrete experiences (e.g., team leadership opportunities, decision-making scenarios), reflect on their observations, connect these to management theories and concepts, and plan future applications, they are actively engaging in Kolb's learning cycle. The journaling process particularly strengthens the reflective observation and abstract conceptualization phases, helping students bridge the gap between experience and theory (Morrison, 1996). This alignment makes journaling an especially powerful tool for research on experiential learning in management education contexts like internships, consulting projects, and simulation exercises.

Table I: *Situation of Participant Journaling within Qualitative Research Traditions*

Qualitative Research Approach	Description	Situation of Participant Journaling
Phenomenology	Phenomenology focuses on understanding the lived experiences of individuals and the meanings they attribute to those experiences. It aims to explore the essence of human experiences and the subjective perspectives of individuals (Dodgson, 2023).	• Journaling aligns with phenomenological approaches that aim to capture lived experiences and subjective perspectives in an in-depth way (Smith *et al.*, 2009). • Journals provide first-person descriptive accounts of phenomena as lived and felt by participants. • Allows researchers to study subjective realities, embodiment, meanings, and lifeworlds.
Reflective Practice	Reflective practice involves the process of self-reflection and critical analysis of one's experiences, actions, and beliefs. It aims to enhance professional development, improve decision-making, and promote learning (Ide and Beddoe, 2023).	• Journaling has roots in reflective practice traditions in education and applied fields (Moon, 2006). • The process of journaling in itself facilitates critical reflection and reflexivity. • Journals document reflections on experiences, beliefs, and practices over time.
Narrative Inquiry	Narrative inquiry focuses on understanding and interpreting individuals' stories and experiences. It emphasizes the importance of personal narratives in constructing meaning and identity (Pino Gavidia and Adu, 2022).	• Participant journals generate data in the form of personal stories and narratives (Clandinin & Connelly, 2000). • Journals reveal meanings participants assign to experiences via narratives. • Allows researchers to undertake narrative analysis of texts.

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Feminist Theory	Feminist theory examines gender inequalities and power dynamics in society. It aims to challenge and transform patriarchal structures and promote gender equality (Driscoll and Krook, 2009).	• Aligned with feminist approaches that value women's voices and lived experiences (Hesse-Biber, 2007). • Journals can empower oppressed groups to tell their stories. • Sensitive to relationships between researcher and participants.
Ethnography	Ethnography: Ethnography involves immersing oneself in a specific cultural or social group to understand their beliefs, practices, and behaviors. It emphasizes participant observation and in-depth interviews (Dania *et al.*, 2021).	• Journals can reveal insider perspectives from participants on their cultural contexts and social worlds. • Provides subjective data to complement ethnographic observations and interviews.
Grounded Theory	Grounded Theory: Grounded theory is an inductive approach that aims to develop theories based on empirical data. It involves constant comparison and iterative analysis to generate concepts and categories (Schroeder *et al.*, 2008)	• Early open-ended journaling can help generate concepts to inform the development of theories. • Journals contain raw experiential data from which new theoretical frameworks can be inductively derived.
Case Study	Case Study: A case study is an in-depth investigation of a particular individual, group, or phenomenon. It provides a detailed analysis of a specific context and can involve multiple data sources (Rashid *et al.*, 2019)	• Detailed, personal journals help provide an in-depth understanding of a case by offering a subjective record of experiences. • The journal becomes one rich data source in the multi-source approach of case study research.
Participatory Action Research	Participatory Action Research: Participatory action research involves collaboration between researchers and participants to address social issues and promote social change. It emphasizes the active involvement of participants in the research process (Harding *et al.*, 2021).	• Journaling is participatory by valuing participant voices and treating them as co-researchers. • The process can facilitate participant reflection to spark change.
Critical Research	Critical Research: Critical research examines power structures, social inequalities, and injustices. It aims to challenge dominant ideologies and promote social transformation (Osafo and Yawson, 2021; Yawson, 2021).	• Journals can empower oppressed groups to share counternarratives and experiences of inequality/discrimination. • Provides subjective data on social power dynamics.

Transformative Learning Theory (Mezirow)

Mezirow's transformative learning theory aligns naturally with participant journaling by providing a framework for understanding how students' perspectives on management and leadership evolve through critical reflection (Kitchenham, 2008). Journals capture students' "disorienting dilemmas" when their existing assumptions about business and management are challenged, documenting their journey through Mezirow's phases of transformation (Mälkki,

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2012). The private, reflective space of a journal allows students to explore their changing perspectives on leadership, organizational behavior, and business ethics. Through journaling, researchers can trace how students question their presuppositions, engage in critical reflection, and develop new frames of reference for understanding management concepts. This makes journaling particularly valuable for studying transformative learning in areas like cross-cultural management, business ethics, and leadership development where perspective transformation is a key learning outcome.

Social Cognitive Theory (Bandura)

Bandura's social cognitive theory provides a theoretical lens for using participant journaling to study the development of management self-efficacy and professional identity (Groenewald and Arnold, 2024). Journals capture students' evolving beliefs about their capabilities to perform management tasks, their observations of role models, and their emotional responses to success and failure (Threlfall, 2014). Through journaling, researchers can track how students develop self-efficacy through mastery experiences in management courses, vicarious learning from peers and instructors, social persuasion, and management of emotional states (Fritson and Mandernach, 2009). The longitudinal nature of journaling aligns well with studying the gradual development of management capabilities and professional confidence. This theoretical framework is particularly relevant for research on management skill development, career preparation, and professional identity formation in business education.

Critical Management Education

Critical management education theory frames participant journaling as a tool for documenting how students develop critical consciousness about management practices and organizational power dynamics (Alvesson and Deetz, 2000). Journals provide space for students

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to question dominant management paradigms, explore alternative perspectives, and reflect on the social and ethical implications of business decisions. Through journaling, researchers can study how students develop critical thinking skills, challenge traditional management assumptions, and consider issues of power, inequality, and sustainability in business contexts (Dyck *et al.,* 2012). This theoretical lens is especially valuable for research on business ethics education, corporate social responsibility, sustainable management, and diversity in organizations. Journals capture students' evolving capacity to think critically about management practices and their role in creating more equitable and sustainable organizations.

Use Cases of Participant Journaling

Journaling as a practice in education, counseling, and other fields has a rich history that has evolved over time. While the specific origins of journaling as a practice are difficult to trace, it has been used for centuries as a tool for personal reflection, self-expression, and documentation of experiences. Participant journaling has emerged as an impactful qualitative method across various domains in the social sciences. Researchers have leveraged journaling to gain rich insights into subjective experiences and meaning-making processes from the first-person perspectives of participants.

Applications in Health Research

Numerous studies illustrate the value of journaling for illuminating patient experiences of illness and care. In a pilot randomized controlled trial, researchers used daily diaries to explore "good days" in individuals with advanced cancer, highlighting the importance of understanding day-to-day quality of life in this population (Lazris *et al.,* 2025). A systematic review and meta-analysis found strong evidence for the short-term effectiveness and moderate evidence for long-

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term effectiveness of yoga for chronic low back pain, with participants keeping journals to track their experiences (Cramer *et al.*, 2013).

Journaling has also been utilized as a therapeutic intervention in counseling and therapy. A study examining the effects of expressive writing on psychological and physical health found that writing about emotional experiences was associated with improvements in both physical and psychological health outcomes (Niles *et al.*, 2014). Another study demonstrated that therapeutic journaling can be an effective tool for managing chronic low back pain, with participants showing significant reductions in pain intensity and disability after engaging in a structured journaling program (Mirgain and Singles, 2024). In mental health research, collaborative journaling between patients and researchers has been employed to study recovery processes. A grounded theory study used activity diaries to understand how individuals with advanced cancer manage responsibility through daily activities (Lowe *et al.*, 2020). These studies demonstrate journaling's ability to capture nuanced, longitudinal insights on illness journeys grounded in patients' own words, while also serving as a therapeutic tool for managing various health conditions.

Uses in Tourism and Hospitality Research

Participant journaling has emerged as a valuable tool for capturing tourist experiences, motivations, and satisfaction in real-time. It allows researchers to track affective components of satisfaction and infer travel motivations from travelers' experiences (Coghlan and Pearce, 2010). Digital journaling platforms can support the creation of meaningful narratives and deepen self-awareness by incorporating character strengths (Wan *et al.*, 2023). Reflective journals enhance learning experiences during field trips, promoting critical reflection and self-awareness (Layen and Hattingh, 2020). Journaling also facilitates the exploration of coping and co-creation

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strategies in tourist experiences (Prebensen and Foss, 2011). However, researchers must address challenges such as poor participation and participants feeling exposed (Hayman et al., 2012). Despite these challenges, journaling remains an effective method for accessing rich qualitative data on tourists' in-the-moment perceptions, overcoming limitations of post-hoc surveys and supporting memorable and meaningful tourism experiences (Wan *et al.*, 2023).

Applications in Educational Research

In the field of education, journaling has been recognized as a valuable tool for promoting reflective practice among educators. It allows teachers to document their thoughts, observations, and reflections on their teaching practices, student interactions, and classroom experiences (Dreyer, 2015). Journaling in education can facilitate professional growth, self-awareness, and the development of effective teaching strategies (Zarestky and Bigler, 2021).

Journaling serves as a powerful educational tool that bridges the gap between student and professional roles while fostering deep self-reflection and growth (Zarestky and Bigler, 2021). Through regular journaling practice, students develop stronger metacognitive awareness and critical thinking skills, learning to analyze their experiences and improve their strategies across various disciplines (Alt and Raichel, 2020). While some initially resist the practice, many come to value journaling's ability to shape professional identity and enhance self-regulated learning. Its flexibility makes it valuable across different educational contexts, from preservice teachers to postgraduate students. Studies consistently show that structured reflective journaling supports the development of problem-solving abilities, independence, and innovative thinking - essential qualities for lifelong learning and professional development in education (Alt and Raichel, 2020).

The appropriation of journaling as a social science research tool has occurred as researchers recognized its potential for capturing rich qualitative data. Journaling allows

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participants to provide detailed and subjective accounts of their experiences, thoughts, and emotions, which can be valuable for understanding complex phenomena (Morrison, 1996). Researchers have incorporated participant journaling into their studies to explore various topics, such as the experiences of marginalized populations, the impact of interventions, and the process of change (Wester et al., 2021).

As social science research has evolved, the use of journaling as a research tool has become more standardized and methodologically rigorous. Researchers have developed guidelines and frameworks for conducting and analyzing journaling data, ensuring ethical considerations and maintaining rigor in the research process (Wester *et al.*, 2021). The integration of journaling into research methodologies has expanded the possibilities for understanding human experiences and generating knowledge in fields such as education, counseling, and social sciences.

Applications in Management Education Research

Participant journaling has emerged as a particularly valuable methodological tool within management education research across several key domains. The method has gained traction as qualitative research has become increasingly recognized for capturing rich and detailed accounts of participants' experiences, perceptions, and emotions (Pearce et al., 2019). In leadership development and experiential learning contexts, participant journaling serves as a critical bridge between classroom theory and practical application, aligning with broader trends in mixed methods research approaches in management education (Plano Clark, 2010).

Studies like Broom et al. (2014) have demonstrated how participant journals can provide valuable insights into self-care practices and everyday expertise development. This documentation offers researchers detailed accounts of how management knowledge transfers to

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practice, with journals capturing information in participants' own words and from their point of view (Jacelon & Imperio, 2005). The longitudinal nature of journal data allows researchers to obtain insights into how participants' perceptions and experiences evolve over time (Hayman et al., 2012).

Recent applications in educational contexts, such as Macedonia and Weiss (2022) study of teaching experiences during global challenges, demonstrate how journaling combined with follow-up interviews can provide deeper understanding of participant perspectives on support and development. This aligns with Minott's (2008) findings on using participant journaling to analyze types of reflection in which pre-service professionals engage. The journaling process itself encourages reflection and meta-cognition, as articulating thoughts in writing causes participants to be more conscious of their cognitive processes (Ullrich & Lutgendorf, 2002).

Research by Oliphant and Bennett (2020) has shown how reflexivity journaling can be particularly valuable in understanding cross-cultural experiences and reducing the emic-etic divide in qualitative research. This makes journaling especially relevant for studying international management education and cross-cultural competency development.

Table 2 summarizes the benefits, strengths, challenges, weaknesses, and best practices of participant journaling as a qualitative social science research method.

Table II: *Benefits, strengths, challenges, weaknesses, and best practices of participant journaling*

Benefits and Strengths	Challenges and Weaknesses
• Elicits rich, detailed subjective data grounded in personal experiences. • Captures thoughts, feelings, and events near real-time they occur. • Empowers participants as collaborators in the research process. • Minimizes retrospective bias common in post-hoc interviews and focus groups.	• Participant fatigue if journaling period is too long • Literacy barriers for some participants • Privacy/ethical issues around reporting sensitive data • Complex, unstructured datasets require extensive coding • Subjective data requires validation through triangulation

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• Provides insights into social worlds and contexts of participants • Captures development of management competencies	• Maintaining student engagement amid competing demands
Best Practices	
• Provide clear protocols and writing prompts • Offer examples of ideal journal entries • Give participants basic training in journaling methods • Reassure confidentiality of sensitive information • Schedule periodic debriefs during and after journaling • Consider combining with other qualitative methods • Align journal prompts with management learning objectives	

Areas for Further Research

Advancing conceptual understanding of the use of journals in research will require continued methodological development in the areas related to rigor, comparative analysis, and critical self-appraisal of the journaling process itself. Future research in participant journaling for management education should focus on several key directions that could enhance its effectiveness as a research methodology. The growing prevalence of digital platforms warrants systematic investigation into how technology-enabled journaling tools can improve data collection, analysis, and student engagement in management education research. Studies need to examine how features like mobile accessibility, multimedia integration, and real-time analytics might enhance the quality and usability of journal data.

Critical attention should be given to developing robust approaches for integrating qualitative journal data with quantitative learning assessments. This could involve creating frameworks for connecting students' reflective insights with measurable learning outcomes in management courses. As management education becomes increasingly global, research should explore how journaling practices and effectiveness vary across cultural contexts, particularly in international management programs and cross-cultural learning environments.

Longitudinal studies are needed to track the extended impact of journaling on management skill development beyond the immediate academic context. This includes

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investigating how journaling during management education influences professional development, decision-making capabilities, and leadership growth in subsequent career stages. Such research could provide valuable insights into the long-term effectiveness of journaling as both a learning tool and research method in management education.

Developing standards for journal analysis and reporting

One of the key areas needing advancement in participant journaling as a qualitative research method is the establishment of clear standards and guidelines for analysis and reporting (O'Brien *et al.*, 2014). Currently, there is a wide variety of analytical techniques utilized, ranging from coding methods to narrative analysis frameworks (de Farias *et al.*, 2021). This diversity can be seen as a strength, but it also poses challenges for assessing quality and developing shared methodological understandings. Best practices are emerging, such as initial open descriptive coding followed by deeper layers of interpretation and theorization (de Farias *et al.*, 2021). However, there is ongoing debate regarding the appropriate balance between holistic versus categorical approaches and *emic* versus *etic* analytical stances (de Farias *et al.*, 2021). Researchers have yet to comprehensively delineate how techniques like thematic analysis, grounded theory, or narrative inquiry should be tailored specifically for participant journal data (de Farias *et al.*, 2021). Clear reporting standards are also essential for participant journals to achieve transparency and trustworthiness (Weiss *et al.*, 2023). Confidentiality of human subjects is a paramount ethical concern, but excessive redaction risks reducing the richness of the narratives (O'Brien *et al.*, 2014). More guidance is needed to negotiate this balance and determine the best formats for communicating content and analytical processes in a clear, compelling, and ethical manner. Analytical and reporting standards will need to evolve iteratively through scholarly debate, field testing of techniques, and accumulating best practices.

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Construct validity and reliability measures

Ensuring validity and reliability is vital for cementing participant journaling as a rigorous qualitative methodology (Shenton, 2004). Validity refers to the accuracy and trustworthiness of findings, which can be approached in participant journals through strategies like member checking, rich description, and triangulation with other data sources. However, there is need for comparative research on which validity techniques are most applicable and effective for journal data specifically. For example, given the subjective nature of participant journals, is member checking with participants about derived themes more critical than for other qualitative data like interviews? Or does the raw diary content already provide sufficient descriptive validity without need for respondent confirmation? Such questions require empirical examination through meta-research.

Reliability for participant journals also warrants attention, such as carefully designed intercoder reliability studies. Since participant journal analysis involves substantial interpretation, assessing consistency in deriving codes and themes across different analysts will be important for establishing the stability and robustness of findings (Miner *et al.*, 2023). Reliability procedures like calculating intercoder percentages, auditing trails, and comparative coding could be tailored and tested for journal datasets. However, some argue that judging qualitative work strictly by positivistic reliability criteria is inappropriate. Balancing reliability and rich descriptive validity may entail trade-offs requiring guidance (Bradshaw *et al.*, 2017). Continuing methodological research on validity and reliability procedures, their epistemological underpinnings, and their fit and utility for journaling specifically can help strengthen journaling as a credible approach aligned with trustworthiness principles in qualitative research overall.

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Comparing participant journals to other data sources:

An important direction for further research is conducting comparative studies analyzing how findings derived from participant journals converge or diverge from other qualitative data sources like interviews, focus groups, observations, and surveys. Triangulation between participant journals and other methods could reveal the unique affordances and limitations of journaling. For example, intensive triangulation may show that participant journals provide more finely grained accounts of subjective experiences over time compared to one-off retrospective interviews. Alternatively, data source comparisons might illuminate critical blindspots in participant journal accounts that observations or in-person methods can complement.

Understanding these distinctions will be key for determining the most impactful and appropriate uses of participant journaling versus situations where other methods or mixed methods are preferable. For example, studies could compare therapist-patient journals versus interviews when evaluating a new therapy program. Or researchers could triangulate tourist journals with ethnographic observations when studying experiences at a heritage site. Meticulous triangulation can elucidate if participant journals offer distinct first-person perspectives, reducing recall bias, or if other methods capture different facets of the same phenomena. Findings from convergence and divergence across sources can guide recommendations on optimal, ethical usage of participant journals. Further comparative work holds promise for delineating the particular niche participant journals can fill within a broader qualitative methodological toolkit, helping maximize their value. The fuller potential of this emerging method rests partly on comprehending its relationships to established approaches through rigorous mixed methods investigation.

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Examining impact of journaling on researchers and participants

A critical area in need of greater research is investigating the experience and effects of Participant journaling for both study participants and qualitative researchers themselves. At present, participant journaling is mainly conceptualized as a tool for collecting data, with less examination of the journaling process itself. However, there are indications it may exert more profound influences on those involved. Participants may experience benefits like self-reflection, empowerment in voicing their stories, and greater insight into their own lives. Conversely, lengthy journaling could prove burdensome. Understanding these impacts could improve ethical implementation and informed consent. For researchers, keeping journals on methodological decisions and reflections could enrich metacognition on study processes, but also introduce issues like observer bias. Further exploration is warranted.

Possible research directions include in-depth interviews, focus groups, surveys, or journaling itself to capture participants' and researchers' perceptions of journaling and its personal and methodological influences. A key question is whether it is solely a data elicitation tool, or can foster learning, meaning-making, and growth for authors. Does participant journaling impact researcher positionality, reflexivity, and analytical lens? Are certain groups more or less likely to benefit? Such complex questions warrant sophisticated qualitative and quantitative inquiry to properly situate participant journaling within a holistic ethical framework encompassing its effects on living beings, not just textual data. Findings would inform recommendations on researcher preparation, participant supports, data security, and other key procedures. The full potential of journaling will only be realized through nuanced understanding

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of its human impacts—how it may transform perspectives, deepen self-awareness, or even catalyze positive change for those involved.

Conclusion

This critical review aimed to provide a comprehensive synthesis and appraisal of participant journaling as an emerging qualitative research method. The origins of journaling were traced to several traditions including phenomenology, reflexive practice, and narrative inquiry that privilege subjective experiences and stories as data. As outlined, journaling is proposed to offer a number of strengths as a research tool, including eliciting rich, detailed accounts grounded in personal narratives, capturing data in real-time, minimizing retrospective bias, and empowering participants as collaborators in the meaning-making process. However, important critiques and limitations were also discussed, such as issues of participant burden, privacy/ethical concerns, dataset complexity, and requirements for rigorous validation through triangulation.

While the literature review indicates journaling holds substantial promise, the discussions also highlight the significant conceptual development still needed for this method to achieve its full potential. Clear standards are lacking for best practices in journaling implementation, ethical protocols, confidentiality procedures, data analysis approaches, and transparent reporting formats. Comparative work is also needed to systematically ascertain the specific types of insights journals can uniquely provide versus other qualitative data sources. Critical examination of the impacts of journaling on both researchers and participants remains limited.

In moving forward, it is clear that participant journaling offers distinctive strengths as a human-centered, collaborative, and meaning-focused research method that warrants ongoing refinement, thoughtful application, and continued methodological innovation. With further conceptual maturation and collective learning, journaling approaches can be refined to serve as a

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profoundly empowering and illuminating qualitative data source when implemented with appropriate rigor. While this review indicates journaling holds substantial promise for management education research, significant conceptual development is still needed. Clear standards are lacking for best practices in implementing journaling in management classrooms, analyzing student reflections, and connecting findings to program learning objectives.

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Table I: *Situation of Participant Journaling within Qualitative Research Traditions*

Qualitative Research Approach	Description	Situation of Participant Journaling
Phenomenology	Phenomenology focuses on understanding the lived experiences of individuals and the meanings they attribute to those experiences. It aims to explore the essence of human experiences and the subjective perspectives of individuals (Dodgson, 2023).	• Journaling aligns with phenomenological approaches that aim to capture lived experiences and subjective perspectives in an in-depth way (Smith *et al.*, 2009). • Journals provide first-person descriptive accounts of phenomena as lived and felt by participants. • Allows researchers to study subjective realities, embodiment, meanings, and lifeworlds.
Reflective Practice	Reflective practice involves the process of self-reflection and critical analysis of one's experiences, actions, and beliefs. It aims to enhance professional development, improve decision-making, and promote learning (Ide and Beddoe, 2023).	• Journaling has roots in reflective practice traditions in education and applied fields (Moon, 2006). • The process of journaling in itself facilitates critical reflection and reflexivity. • Journals document reflections on experiences, beliefs, and practices over time.
Narrative Inquiry	Narrative inquiry focuses on understanding and interpreting individuals' stories and experiences. It emphasizes the importance of personal narratives in constructing meaning and identity (Pino Gavidia and Adu, 2022).	• Participant journals generate data in the form of personal stories and narratives (Clandinin & Connelly, 2000). • Journals reveal meanings participants assign to experiences via narratives. • Allows researchers to undertake narrative analysis of texts.
Feminist Theory	Feminist theory examines gender inequalities and power dynamics in society. It aims to challenge and transform patriarchal structures and promote gender equality (Driscoll and Krook, 2009).	• Aligned with feminist approaches that value women's voices and lived experiences (Hesse-Biber, 2007). • Journals can empower oppressed groups to tell their stories. • Sensitive to relationships between researcher and participants.
Ethnography	Ethnography: Ethnography involves immersing oneself in a specific cultural or social group to understand their beliefs, practices, and behaviors. It emphasizes participant observation and in-depth interviews (Dania *et al.*, 2021).	• Journals can reveal insider perspectives from participants on their cultural contexts and social worlds. • Provides subjective data to complement ethnographic observations and interviews.
Grounded Theory	Grounded Theory: Grounded theory is an inductive approach that aims to develop theories based on empirical data. It involves constant comparison and iterative analysis to generate concepts and categories (Schroeder *et al.*, 2008)	• Early open-ended journaling can help generate concepts to inform the development of theories. • Journals contain raw experiential data from which new theoretical frameworks can be inductively derived.

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Case Study	Case Study: A case study is an in-depth investigation of a particular individual, group, or phenomenon. It provides a detailed analysis of a specific context and can involve multiple data sources (Rashid *et al.*, 2019)	• Detailed, personal journals help provide an in-depth understanding of a case by offering a subjective record of experiences. • The journal becomes one rich data source in the multi-source approach of case study research.
Participatory Action Research	Participatory Action Research: Participatory action research involves collaboration between researchers and participants to address social issues and promote social change. It emphasizes the active involvement of participants in the research process (Harding *et al.*, 2021).	• Journaling is participatory by valuing participant voices and treating them as co-researchers. • The process can facilitate participant reflection to spark change.
Critical Research	Critical Research: Critical research examines power structures, social inequalities, and injustices. It aims to challenge dominant ideologies and promote social transformation (Osafo and Yawson, 2021; Yawson, 2021).	• Journals can empower oppressed groups to share counternarratives and experiences of inequality/discrimination. • Provides subjective data on social power dynamics.

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Table II: *Benefits, strengths, challenges, weaknesses, and best practices of participant journaling*

Benefits and Strengths	Challenges and Weaknesses
• Elicits rich, detailed subjective data grounded in personal experiences. • Captures thoughts, feelings, and events near real-time they occur. • Empowers participants as collaborators in the research process. • Minimizes retrospective bias common in post-hoc interviews and focus groups. • Provides insights into social worlds and contexts of participants • Captures development of management competencies	• Participant fatigue if journaling period is too long • Literacy barriers for some participants • Privacy/ethical issues around reporting sensitive data • Complex, unstructured datasets require extensive coding • Subjective data requires validation through triangulation • Maintaining student engagement amid competing demands
Best Practices	
• Provide clear protocols and writing prompts • Offer examples of ideal journal entries • Give participants basic training in journaling methods • Reassure confidentiality of sensitive information • Schedule periodic debriefs during and after journaling • Consider combining with other qualitative methods • Align journal prompts with management learning objectives	

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